Underrepresentation of Racial and Ethnic Minority Group Members in Advanced Counseling and Psychology Occupations

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Abstract

The study examines whether there is an underrepresentation of racial and ethnic minority group members in counseling and psychology occupations that include marriage and family therapists. Representation ratios are computed in these occupations by race/ethnicity and gender using the American Community Census (ACS) five year-year sample, 2007-2011 (5 out of 100) sample. The representation ratio is the ratio of the kth group's probability of being employed in the occupation to the overall probability of employment in the occupation. These probabilities are computed for persons 18-60 years of age, across different levels of post-secondary education. We compute the representation ratios for all counselors, counselors with advanced (Masters, Professional and Doctorate) degrees, and psychologists with advanced degrees. We test the hypothesis that there are statistically significant differences in the representation ratios between white, non-Hispanics and specific racial and ethnic minority group members.

Hypotheses

- There is an underrepresentation of racial and ethnic minority group members among persons employed as counselors and psychologists
- The underrepresentation is greater among psychologists vs. counselors

Methods

The representation of the kth group in a given occupation is equal to the ratio of the *k*th group's probability of being in the profession to the overall probability of being in the profession. (Myers, Turner, 2004). Let $P(f)$ denote the probability of being a counselor or psychologist. Let $P^k(f)$ be the *k*th group's probability of being a counselor or psychologist. Then, R^k, the representation ratio for the *k*th group is given by:

$$R^k = \frac{P^k(f)}{P(f)}$$

To test the hypothesis that the representation ratio is different from one, (e.g., that there is an underrepresentation of group k in the profession) we used the STATA difference in proportions test, **prtest**, for 95% confidence intervals.

Sample

The American Community Survey (ACS) is annually updated data for the same areas surveyed via the decennial census long-form sample. This project uses the ACS 5 year-year sample, 2007-2011 (5 in 100 national random sample of the population). The five-year sample contains all households and persons from the 1 percent ACS samples from 2007, 2008, 2009, 2010, and 2011.

Definition of Occupations

Counselors *(SOC Code: 21-1010)*: Substance Abuse and Behavioral Counselors; Marriage and Family Therapists; Mental Health Counselors; Rehabilitation Counselors; Educational, Guidance, School and Vocational Counselors; and all other Counselors.

Psychologists *(SOC Code: 19-3030)*: Clinical, Counseling, and School Psychologists; Industrial-Organizational Psychologists; and all other Psychologists.

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Results

Table 1 reports the representation ratios by race/ethnicity and gender for counselors and psychologists using the ACS 5 year-year sample, 2007-2011.
Figure 1 reproduces these ratios comparing blacks vs. whites and Southeast Asians vs. all other Asians by education level.

Table 1: Representation Ratios by Race/Ethnic and Gender

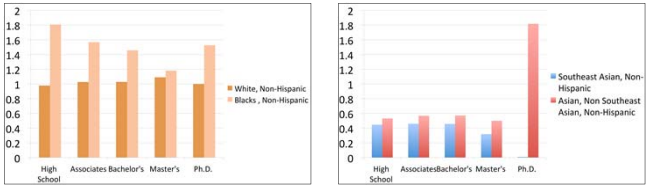
	White Non-Hispanics	Black Non-Hispanics	American Indian Non-Hispanics	Southeast Asian Non-Hispanics	All other Asian Non-Hispanics	Hispanics	All Others
Counselors							
Total	0.9787*	1.8298*	1.5319*	0.4468*	0.5319*	0.6596*	1.2553*
Males	0.9231*	2.6153*	1.730*	0.5384*	0.6538*	0.6154*	1.2692*
Females	1.0141	1.4571*	1.4000*	0.3857*	0.5000*	0.7286*	1.2286*
Psychologists							
Total	1.2727*	0.5455*	0.6364*	0.3636*	0.6364*	0.4545*	0.9091
Males	1.3333*	0.6667*	0.5000*	0.3333*	0.5000*	0.3333*	0.8333
Females	1.2353*	0.4118*	0.7059*	0.3529*	0.6471*	0.4706*	0.9412

*Source: Authors' computations from the ACS, Five-Year (5/100) Sample, 2007-2011. * = statistically significant at 5% level, two-tailed difference in proportions test*

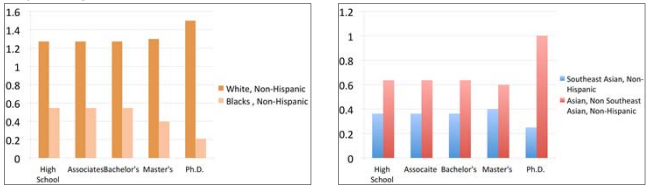
There is a greater representation of minorities among counselors relative to psychologists. There is an underrepresentation of all racial/ethnic minority groups for both genders relative to whites among psychologists. These results are all statistically significant at the 5-percent level.

Figure 1: Representation Ratios by Terminal Degree

Counselors



Psychologists



The representation of black non-Hispanics exceeds that of white non-Hispanics among counselors; the reverse is true among psychologists. These differences persist across all education levels. Southeast Asians have lower representation ratios than other Asians at all education levels among both counselors and psychologists.

Discussion

Persons employed in such professions as *Marriage and Family Therapists* are found in two closely allied census occupations: Counselors and Psychologists. African Americans and American Indians are heavily concentrated in the counseling portion of these professions whereas all racial and ethnic minority group members are underrepresented among psychologists.

Hispanics, Asian Americans, and particularly Southeast Asians are significantly underrepresented in both counseling and psychology, although Hispanics and Southeast Asians uniformly face lower representation among psychologists vs. counselors.

These disparities persist across all education levels. Possible explanations for the heavier concentration of minorities among counselors vs. psychologists include the fact that such counseling fields as drug abuse and addiction counselors serve clients who themselves are disproportionately minorities. Another explanation is that the overrepresentation in one field (e.g. counselor) stems from the *underrepresentation* in other fields where educational requirements and wages are higher. It is easy to demonstrate that wages are lower in counselor occupations than among psychologists.

Table 2 reveals that there is a sizeable disparity in the annual wage and salary income between psychologists and counselors at every education level. This project points to the problem of uneven distribution of minorities among counselors vs. psychologists. We conclude that there is a need to increase the number of racial and ethnic minorities across all mental/behavioral health professionals, thus creating a culturally competent workforce to meet the needs of the expanding minority population of the United States.

Table 2: Mean Annual Wage and Salary Income of Counselors and Psychologists, 2007-2011

Education Level	Counselors	Psychologists	% Gap
Highschool+	$ 37,848	$ 58,275	35%
2 year of college +	$ 41,098	$ 58,322	30%
Bachelor +	$ 41,940	$ 58,377	28%
Master+	$ 47,147	$ 59,843	21%
Phd+	$ 53,389	$ 70,704	24%
Total	$ 37,681	$ 58,263	35%

Source: ACS, Five Year 5/100 Sample, 2007-2011; Persons 18-60 with positive wage and salary incomes; all differences are

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